the foundations for what we know of today as Mahayana, the ‘Great Vehicle or Path’. It placed new emphasis on compassion and the intervention of a class of enlightened beings known as Bodhisattvas, whose transcendent wisdom had allowed them to achieve Buddhahood but who out of compassion for their fellow beings postponed their own entry into nirvana in order to end human suffering. This reinterpretation would eventually lead to a final schism that had long been coming between these new thinkers and those who continued to follow the more austere teachings of Theravada, the Path of the Elders.

Nagarjuna was perhaps the foremost but only one of the new thinkers who now emerged out of this hothouse of philosophical debate. Many of the central texts of the Madyamaka teaching are attributed to Nagarjuna but are more likely to have been written by his chief disciple Aryadeva or later adherents. The one text that all scholars seem happy to accept as his is the shastra known as the *Mulamadhyamakakarika*, *or* ‘Fundamental Verses from the Middle Way’, which covers the essentials of his thinking in 448 verses. The higher metaphysics behind the teaching that so profoundly reshaped the course of Buddhism are quite beyond me, so I refer the interested reader to someone who knows what they are talking about.[10]

This Satavahana-sponsored Buddhist culture extended as far north across the Narmada as Sanchi and the Ajanta caves. Within the Krishna Valley itself it was long thought that the only important stupa sites were at Amaravati, Bhattiprolu, Jaggayyapeta and Nagarjunakonda. However, thanks to the work of the Andhra circle of the ASI two more important stupa sites have in recent years been added to the list: Phanigiri and Kanaganahalli. These names still mean very little in India, which is a pity, because Kanaganahalli in particular will in time become as world